

TIMID INDIA

Sharm el-Sheikh was symptomatic of what ails India's foreign policy. The dangerous drift in its dealings with neighbours and major world powers has exacted a heavy toll.

AP PHOTO/AMR NABIL



Pakistan

In pushing through an ill-conceived, ill-prepared and ill-timed initiative to break the deadlock, Manmohan blew his chances on India's principal foreign policy challenge.

MANMOHAN WITH GILANI
AT SHARM EL-SHEIKH

AP PHOTO/
MANISH SWARUP

By Raj Chengappa

Timid

Pronunciation: \ 'ti-məd \ ; *Function:* adjective

Etymology: Latin *timidus*, from *timere* to fear

1: lacking in courage or self-confidence

2: lacking in boldness or determination

The Merriam Webster's Online Dictionary

There is no better word to sum up the primary shortcoming of India's foreign policy. Maybe Prime Minister Manmohan Singh would find it too harsh. After all, in his first term as prime minister hadn't he boldly gone where no Indian leader had in recent times and pulled off a major diplomatic victory by ending decades of India's nuclear apartheid. So maybe he had visions of repeating his success by tackling an even more vexatious issue: building a durable peace with Pakistan. It certainly is in India's national interest. It also has the potential to win him a Nobel Peace Prize and forever etch his name in the annals of world history—a reward big enough for every leader to give everything that he or she has got. But as Henry Kissinger once observed: "Each success only buys an admission ticket to a more difficult problem."

In Manmohan's case, his success with the Indo-US deal is now also threatening to be his ticket to failure. In pushing through an ill-conceived, ill-prepared and poorly timed initiative to break the deadlock in relations with Pakistan, Manmohan not only blew his chances of affecting a breakthrough but also squandered much of the political capital and respect he had earned by winning a second term in office. After the 26/11 Mumbai attacks, how to tackle Pakistan had become India's principal foreign policy challenge. With reams of evidence pointing to Pakistan's complicity in the matter, how Manmohan dealt with India's troublesome neighbour would, along with a sustained economic recovery, define the success of UPA 2.0.

Manmohan demonstrated firmness when he met Pakistan President Asif Ali Zardari on June 16 at